

Making the Corporate Platform Decision

Peter S. Kastner
Aberdeen Group, Inc..
One Boston Place
Boston, Mass. 02108
(617) 723-7890



Aberdeen Group

- Boston-based market research and consulting firm
- Works with both suppliers and buyer organizations
- Technology-rich but business management focused
 - the impact of technology on a business
- Key analyst/consultants have both supplier and IS Department experience
- Willing to look at small one-time problems or big long-term ones
- World-class in who's hot and who's not in supplier capabilities

Why Use a Consultant?

To solve tough problems where internally

- the answer is unknown
- there are multiple, conflicting answers ... the political factors
- there is a high risk for a wrong decision
- there is a high cost for a wrong decision
- maybe doing something is a bad idea
- A consultant is an objective outsider
- A consultant specialist can help on a specialized problem

Aberdeen's Assignment

- Background is 1994 Commercial Lines Coop review
 - Stay with AT&T Cooperation?
 - Commercial Lines platform decisions
 - Germ of the Corporate Platform vision
- A year later ...
- Analyze the *business impact* of the planned Corporate Platform, focusing on:
 - vulnerabilities and business risks
 - technology suitability
 - maturity
 - likely timing scenarios
 - synergy of prior ITT Hartford experiences
 - ongoing Aberdeen research
 - other factors

Corporate Platform Decision: What We Looked At

- Desktop operating system
- Application/DB operating system
- Network operating system
- Network management
- Desktop applications
- Groupware
- Desktop office automation
- 3270 emulator
- Electronic mail
- Group calendar
- Supply cabinet functionality
- Platform management tools

Key Issues

Aberdeen's Summary Findings (May '95)

- ITT Hartford planning has been excellent, and preliminary plans show considerable effort at finding the devil in the details
- Microsoft Windows95 is the runaway choice as desktop OS, but general availability timing will be later than required
- A dual workgroup-OS strategy built around Windows NT/AS and Novell NetWare is pragmatic
- System and network management, particularly distributed software management, deserve on-going planning attention
- Other planned corporate platform technology choices are sensible

Desktop OS Issues (May 1995)

- Candidates
 - Microsoft Windows95
 - » Not shipping. May be delayed.
 - IBM OS/2 Warp
 - » Little ISV support, commitment
 - Microsoft NT Workstation
 - » GUI will change to Win95; big footprint
- Microsoft Windows95 is the best choice
 - Everybody proclaims it the market winner
 - Huge ISV support for applications
 - Will work well with either NT or NetWare as the workgroup server
 - Windows 3.1 is the largest Hartford desktop
 - Full compatibility with existing 16-bit apps
 - Good built-in support for remote access
 - More crash-proof than DOS/Windows

Conclusions

- There is an overwhelming business case for ITT Hartford to have a Common IT Platform across business units
- The Platform decision was made systematically and professionally
- There were some tough choices
- The choices you make today are not necessarily the ones you would make tomorrow
- It was prudent to call in Aberdeen on this project